



IF ANYTHING, THE EXPERIENCE OF PAST EDITIONS HAS TAUGHT INDIAN SHOOTERS TO APPROACH THE OLYMPICS WITH MORE CARE AND DILIGENCE

It's important to keep in mind that only 340 athletes will be participating in shooting events at the Olympics. These consist of 15 competitions, including three mixed events. Shooters who qualify for individual events can compete in mixed events.

China leads the table of Olympic quota winners so far, with 22, while India is No.2. The USA has 18, followed by Korea (15), Australia (12), France (12), Egypt (11), and Germany (10) out of the 63 countries (as of March 7) that have managed to win the quota places. There will be 45 medals up for grabs.

The bitter experience of big squads of Indian shooters returning empty-handed from the last two Olympics in Rio and Tokyo may be

Booking a spot: Sift Kaur Samra secured a Paris 2024 Olympics quota for India at the ISSF World Championship 2023 after finishing fifth in the women's 50m rifle 3 positions in Baku, Azerbaijan.

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fresh in memory. It may rankle a lot more than the joy derived from the brilliant performances of Rajyavardhan Rathore (Silver, double trap, Athens 2004), Abhinav Bindra (Gold, 10m air rifle, Beijing 2008), Vijay Kumar (Silver, 25m rapid fire pistol, London 2012), and Gagan Narang (Bronze, 10m air rifle, London 2012).

If anything, the experience has taught Indian shooters to approach

the Olympics with more care and diligence. Indian shooters are world-class, no doubt, as they have shown over the years in global competitions. What is required is a nice passage to help them peak at the right time to strike the medals that matter in world sports, from July 27 to August 5, when the shooting events are staged at the Olympics in France.

"It is one grinder leading up to the Games. The team management must ensure that the athletes are not burned out. The Olympics is much

more demanding, especially psychologically," said Beijing Games gold medallist and air rifle ace Abhinav Bindra.

Abhinav tried to put things in perspective by considering the healthy scenario of Indian shooters performing well while reflecting on the earlier struggles of world-class Indian shooting teams during the Games.

"Last time, before the Tokyo Olympics, Indian shooters were away from home for a long time. The athletes were quite jaded. One size is not going to fit all. Young athletes, young minds. A 17-year-old's mind works differently. Maybe they want to be at home. Maybe they miss their family. As athletes, we are human beings first. The softer elements matter. The battery must be full when our shooters line up for their events in Paris," said Abhinav.

The shooters, if they are well prepared physically, technically, mentally, and emotionally, will have enhanced chances to strike medals this time in the Games.

All events except for the mixed pairs events of air pistol, air rifle, and